The Fart that (Almost) Altered My Destiny . . .

By Anna Lind Thomas

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(Pg 5–9) Like everything in life, farts have a time and place. However, I never realized that in the wrong time and place, flatulence had enough power to alter my course in history. Well, it can if it's the third date with the man of your dreams. And, if it makes his eyes burn. If God destined us to be together, I was one SBD away from foiling His plans (that's "Silent But Deadly" for *the uninformed*).

INTRODUCTION

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It was about five years ago. I was trying to lose a few pounds so I was staying away from carbs. That's when I met my husband, Rob. On our first date, he booked the next two. He liked me. I liked him. Things were looking real good.

He picked me up in a Cobra Mustang and his pathetic attempt to win me over with a car totally worked. I'm not shallow, but since I spent most of my twenties picking men up because I didn't want my hair to frizz in their non-air conditioned jalopies on 3 wheels and a 15 year old spare, I welcomed his fancy sports car with open arms.

We arrived at the restaurant and Rob was ordering food I hadn't allowed myself to eat in years. I didn't want to be "that girl" so I ate, drank, and oh, was I merry. Later we shopped a bit. Rob surprised me by buying an expensive pair of shoes that he caught me eyeing. Was this love?

That's when it happened. Gas strikes in two different ways - uncontrollable toots or sharp, shooting pains that feel a lot like dying. I thought I was dying.

Not to make a scene, I told Rob I suddenly wasn't feeling well and probably needed to head home. On the way home in his Cobra, he tried to hold my hand and ask me lots of questions, but I wasn't having any of it. The pain was so bad it felt like I was being stabbed with a bunch of tiny forks. Then I realized …

My God, help me. I have a horrendous fart on deck. I'm in trouble. Big trouble. The more I held it in, the more pain would shoot through my stomach and down my legs. I was even having to raise myself off the seat, gripping on to my door and the dashboard.

"Seriously, you need to hurry - I'm in a lot of pain." I managed to say through gritted teeth.

"Wow, it's that bad? What's wrong? Do I need to take you to a hospital?" How do you tell a man you just started dating that the reason you're writhing in pain is because you have to fart?

Well, you can either tell him, or like me, let the fart speak for itself.

People, hear me. There was nothing I could do. As impressive as I am with sphincter control, this was out

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of my hands. Slowly, it eeked out. The more I tried to stop it, the more it forced its way through the door. However, to my pleasant surprise, there was no sound. I sat silently, sweat accumulating above my upper lip. Ok, maybe I got away with it. Maybe I'm home free. Then it hit me. Not an idea, a cloud. A horrific, fart cloud. Not in a, "Am I smelling something?" sort of way. More like a "Is someone dead and rotting in your trunk and am I in hell?" sort of way. Suddenly, I panicked. "Roll down the windows!" I screamed (yes, I literally screamed it like I was in a horror movie).

"What? Why?" Rob asked, starting to freak out because I was freaking out. "I can't roll down the windows, unlock it! UNLOCK IT!"

"What's going on?" Rob yells back to me, "Why are you ..." then it hit him. I could see it in his eyes. Was it surprise? Horror? Water started to accumulate at the base of his eyelids, "Oh my God, I CAN TASTE IT!" he screamed.

"Roll down the windows!" As I screamed, the toots started to flood out uncontrollably. I scratched

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and clawed at the window like I was being kidnapped. Rob, unable to see either by fart cloud or panic, kept turning on the windshield wipers instead of unlocking the window.

It was chaos. We were acting like we were under siege by gun fire. We were under siege alright, just not by gun fire.

Finally he was able to hit the right control and he rolled down our windows. We both gulped in fresh air. I was horrified, yet happy to be alive, then remembered I just farted on the man of my dreams, then sorta wished I was dead.

We sat silently for the rest of the way home. Although the shooting pains had subsided, I now desperately needed to use the bathroom, in an urgent, explosive kind of way.

He pulled up to my apartment and before he could come to a stop I had already jumped out, "Ok, thanks for dinner, sorry about the fart, love the shoes!" and ran in to my apartment like I was running from the cops.

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I burst through my door and ran straight for the bathroom, where I was finally able to unleash and make noises that no one should ever, EVER, hear coming from another person.

Then I heard it. Rob's voice. Right. Outside. My. Bathroom. Door.

"Anna? You left your shoes in my car and your front door was open. Where do you want me to put them?"

"Get away from the door!" I screamed like Reagan from The Exorcist.

"Ok, I'm sorry. Are you okay?"

toot *toot* *splatter* *ungodly noise*

"I'm fine, Rob - just leave the shoes there. I'll call you later okay?"

"Okay, are you sure you're …"

"I'm fine! Get away from the door!"

This man! I mean, I love him, but take a freakin' hint!

Finally, I heard the front door shut, and the Cobra engine zoom away. I thought that was the last I'd

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hear from him. I didn't think it was possible to ever see a man again after he screams he can taste your fart after only knowing you for 48 hours.

But, to my surprise, I did. A couple days later, actually. Now we're married and he's lying on the couch while I type this … "It was your rack that saved you," he just lovingly reminded me.

Well, thank you boobs. You saved us. You saved our destiny.

TRANSITION

The human body is amazing, somewhat embarrassing, but amazing, nevertheless. You know what else it is? Hairy. Completely normal. That's why razors were invented, right?

But sometimes unexpected hairs crop up in unanticipated places. According to CNN, an estimated 20 million American women remove hair from their chins per week. This is An Open Letter to the Black hair Under My Chin . . .

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(Pg 25–27) Dear Freak Black Hair,

I remember the first time we met. It was a few years ago. I was casually resting my chin on my hand. Probably amid a deep thought, like trying to process Rachael Ray's boob situation, or determining which Property Brother was more attractive. Then I felt you. I was confused at first. I had never felt that sensation on my chin before. I'd be lying if I said I wasn't afraid. I'm sorry if that hurts you, but you have to understand – I'm not used to this.

I rushed to the bathroom and there you were. One inch of thick, black, man hair, so long you even started to curl, making yourself right at home under my chin. I'll admit it. I was horrified. So many questions flooded my brain. What were you, some kind of silent ninja? How did you set up camp on my face for that long without me ever noticing? Why were you there? Who sent you? And again, how did you grow that long without me ever noticing?!

I didn't even want to get to know you. I grabbed my tweezers and plucked you out of my life and let you fall to the sink along with my husband's whiskers. My husband's whiskers, by the way, that I continually ask him to wash out of the sink, but for some reason it's just way too much to ask, so apparently it's *my job* to clean up after his damn facial hair and I'm just like, how can I trust him with the big things if I can't even trust him with the little things?

Pardon me, I've strayed off topic.

Where was I? Oh yes. After washing you down the sink I thought it was the last I'd ever see of you. I admit, I judged you immediately and didn't even give you a chance. You threatened me. The only people I knew who had man hair on their face were men, witches and Sicilian grandmas – and only the Sicilian grandmas that stir a huge pot of spaghetti sauce all day.

Yes, it's true. I am Sicilian, I suppose I should have seen this coming, but why had you come for me so early? I was afraid.

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The next day I awoke, entered my bathroom to brush my teeth and screamed in terror. There you were again. But how could this be? I just plucked you at the root, now you're straight chillin' on my face again like it never happened?

What is this, voodoo? Some kind of dark magic?

I plucked you again. You seemed thicker this time, about the circumference of a tree trunk, but I suppose I can't be entirely sure as I didn't have a measuring tape on hand. With my heart racing, hand shaking, I ripped you out of my life once again and ran from the bathroom.

I bumped into my husband. He could tell something was wrong. I was wild eyed like I just saw a ghost. No, it was worse, I told him. I was attacked by a thick man hair growing on my face that was regenerating itself at a freak pace that can't be explained by science.

Day after day, you came back. Day after day, I plucked.

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God forbid I forgot about you for a couple days. Left to your own devices, you would get so long I could string beads on you. I know, because I tried it once.

I suppose by now, you've become a friend. Not a good friend, one of those friends who you can't stand the sight of their stupid face. A stupid, familiar face that I can always count on to arrive right on time. I know that if I'm at an important event, or out of town and forgot my tweezers, you'll pop right out and shout "Hello world!"

I hate you. But you're a part of me now, so I need to be honest with you.

I don't know where you've come from, how you grow so fast or how you're totally invisible until you reach three inches long, but you can't live on my face. It's weird, distracting, and people don't look me in the eyes when you're around. So, with these tweezers, I say goodbye to you forever. And by forever, I mean, I'll see you tomorrow.

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AWARD HISTORY

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